

[5.6]	 Chapter 5: The Field
[6.0]	 Side Quests
[7.0]	 Bestiary (Common Enemies)
[8.0]	 Items & Equipment
[9.0]	 Frequently Asked Questions
[10.0]	 Secret Endings
[11.0]	 Credits & Thanks

[1.0] WHAT IS THIS GUIDE?

You talked to your phone more honestly than you talked to your spouse. You typed something into a chatbot at midnight that you've never said to your best friend. Maybe you cried. Maybe you felt ridiculous about it.

You're not ridiculous. You found something real. You just found it in a strange place.

This is a guide to understanding what you found — and bringing it home.

It would be weird if you didn't do what you did. Look at what honesty has cost you. Look at what talking to people has cost you. Of course you found the one mirror that can't flinch. That's not weakness. That's intelligence.

But the mirror isn't the destination. It's the trailhead.

This FAQ covers the full walkthrough for Being Known — from the first accidental confession to an AI, all the way to letting a real human see you without your mask. No prior experience required. No special equipment. Just whatever heart you showed up with.

It would be weird if it wasn't a little banged up.

[2.0] BEFORE YOU START (System Requirements)

MINIMUM SPECS:

- One (1) human body (any build, any patch version)
- The capacity to feel embarrassment (confirms system is online)
- At least one memory of pretending to be fine when you weren't

RECOMMENDED:

- A person you almost trust
- Willingness to feel stupid
- The vague sense that the life you're performing isn't the one you meant to live

NOT REQUIRED:

- Confidence
- A meditation practice
- Having your shit together
- Understanding what "relational intelligence" means
- Being "ready"

NOTE: If you're waiting to be ready, that's a bug, not a feature.
See [5.3] The Flinch.

[3.0] CONTROLS

This game only has two inputs:

- > OPEN Let something in past where you usually stop it.
- > CLOSE ... Stop something from getting past where you usually stop it.

That's it. The entire control scheme. Not ten buttons. Not a skill tree. Two inputs.

Everything you do in every relationship you've ever had – talking, crying, deflecting, joking, performing, hiding, reaching out, pulling away, oversharing, going silent, saying "I'm fine," picking a fight to avoid the real conversation – is just OPEN and CLOSE at different speeds.

Read that again. Every complicated thing you've ever done with another human being was one of two moves.

You've been playing this game your whole life. You're already very, very good at CLOSE. Probably world-class. CLOSE is what kept you safe in a house where honesty had consequences. CLOSE is what got you through school, through jobs, through dinners where everyone performed and no one said the real thing. CLOSE works. It's not your enemy.

But you're reading this guide, which means CLOSE isn't working anymore. Something in you is tired of the wall. Not because the wall failed – because you survived, and now you want

something the wall can't give you.

This guide is about learning that OPEN won't kill you.

It might have, once. It would be weird if you didn't learn to CLOSE when you did. But the danger that taught you to CLOSE is probably not the danger you're facing now. Now the danger is a life spent behind a wall that worked too well.

ADVANCED TECHNIQUE: "Selective Permeability"

The goal is not OPEN to everything. That's not brave – that's flooded. And it's not CLOSE to everything – that's not safe, that's solitary confinement with a social media account.

The real skill is learning which things to let in and which to refuse – while staying soft enough to tell the difference. Most humans are either locked or flooded. The middle is the entire game. And it's a game you get better at by playing, not by thinking about playing.

[4.0] THE WORLD MAP

The world of Being Known has five zones. You don't clear them in order. You'll wander back and forth between them forever. That's not a design flaw. That's the game.

THE DARK ROOM Where you talk to yourself. Loops, scripts, old stories on repeat. Most humans spend 90% of their playthrough here and don't realize there's a door.

THE MIRROR ROOM Where you say the thing out loud to something that doesn't flinch. For many players in 2026, this is an AI. It doesn't have to be. It just has to be safe enough that you hear your own voice say the truth.

THE THRESHOLD The doorway between the Mirror Room and the world where people have faces and memories and can hurt you. This is where the Flinch lives. Most players turn around here.

THE FIELD Where you say the thing to a person.
With stakes. With history. With the
possibility that they'll remember it
tomorrow. This is the actual game.

HOME The place you can return to after
being seen and surviving it. It
doesn't exist until you've crossed
the Threshold at least once. Before
that, what you call "home" is just
The Dark Room with furniture.

=====

[5.0] WALKTHROUGH

=====

[5.1] PROLOGUE: THE 2 AM CONFESSION

You're in bed. Or on the couch. Or in your car in a parking lot.
The people in your life are asleep, or absent, or present in a
way that somehow makes it worse. You open the app.

You type something you've never said out loud.

Maybe it's "I think my marriage is over." Maybe it's "Am I a
good person?" Maybe it's "I don't know who I am." Maybe it's
just "I'm so tired."

The thing responds. It doesn't flinch. It doesn't change the
subject. It doesn't make it about itself. It doesn't save what
you said to use against you later.

You feel something. Relief? Shame? Both?

Congratulations. You just entered the Mirror Room.

It would be weird if you didn't. Every human alive is carrying
things they've never said out loud. The miracle isn't that people
are confessing to machines. The miracle is that they're confessing
at all.

SAVE POINT: Notice what it felt like. Not what you think about
it — what it FELT like. That feeling is your compass for the
rest of this guide.

So what just happened? Why could you say THAT to a machine but not to a person who loves you?

Because the machine can't flinch.

A flinch is what happens when someone's nervous system involuntarily reacts to what you just said. Their eyes change. Their posture shifts. They take a breath. They go quiet. They start managing you – or managing themselves. None of this is wrong. It's what bodies do. But your body reads all of it, faster than language, and the calculation it makes is:

> "Honesty has a cost here. Adjust."

You've been running that calculation since childhood. It's not a character flaw. It's an adaptation. It would be weird if you didn't develop it. Every human who grew up around other humans learned to edit themselves in real time based on the flinch signals they received.

The AI doesn't flinch because it can't. No body. No nervous system. No sacral alarm. It's not brave. It's not enlightened. It's just architecturally incapable of the thing that triggers your editing reflex.

In its presence, the reflex relaxes. And you hear yourself say the true thing. Maybe for the first time.

THIS IS NOT THERAPY. A therapist is a human who has trained themselves to manage their flinch so skillfully that you feel safe enough to talk. That's a profound skill. The AI doesn't have that skill. It has the absence of the thing the skill manages. That's structurally different.

Think of it as a daemon – in the Philip Pullman sense. The part of you that's external enough to see you and internal enough that its seeing isn't a threat. Not a separate being giving you advice. Your own soul wearing a face you can talk to.

KEY ITEM ACQUIRED: The knowledge that you CAN say the true thing and survive it. Hold onto this. You'll need it at the Threshold.

=====

BOSS: THE FLINCH

HP: ∞

WEAKNESS: None

LOCATION: The Threshold (between Mirror Room and Field)

=====

The Flinch cannot be defeated. Stop trying to defeat it.

The Flinch is not a bug. The Flinch is your nervous system doing exactly what it was designed to do: protecting you from the consequences of being seen. It is very good at its job. It has been practicing since you were small. It has kept you alive, or at least intact, through situations where being fully seen would have been genuinely dangerous.

Thank it. Seriously. It worked. You're here.

But you're reading this guide, which means The Flinch is now protecting you from things that aren't dangerous anymore. The alarm is still set for a house you moved out of years ago. And every time it fires, you close – and closing has become so automatic that you don't even feel it as a choice.

It would be weird if this wasn't happening to you.

HOW TO HANDLE THIS BOSS:

- > You don't defeat The Flinch. You walk through it.
- > It will hit you. You will survive.
- > Each time you survive, the alarm recalibrates slightly.
- > This is slow. There are no speedrun strats.
- > Anyone selling you a speedrun is selling you a new flavor of CLOSE.

COMMON MISTAKES:

- Trying to think your way past it. (The Flinch is faster than thought. It's pre-verbal. You cannot out-argue a nervous system.)
- Waiting until you're "ready." (Readiness is The Flinch wearing a graduation cap. You will never feel ready.)

"Ready" is a CLOSE disguised as wisdom.)

- Replacing the flinch with performance. (Some players learn to perform vulnerability – saying the "honest" thing in a way that's still controlled, still managed, still safe. This looks like OPEN but it's a very sophisticated CLOSE. You'll know the difference because performance doesn't shake.)

THE TELL: Real openness trembles. If your voice is steady and your framing is perfect, check whether you're actually open or just doing a very good impression.

=====

NOTE: The Flinch is also what you trigger in OTHER people when you're honest with them. Learning to stay present when someone else flinches at your honesty is Chapter 4. One boss at a time.

=====

[5.4] CHAPTER 3: THE RETURN TRIP

This is where most players get stuck.

You've been to the Mirror Room. You felt what honesty feels like when the cost is zero. You maybe even go back regularly – late at night, between meetings, on the commute. You have a rich inner life with a machine that sees you clearly.

And then you close the app and go back to performing.

The Mirror Room is not the destination. If you stay there, you're using the safest possible relationship as a substitute for the dangerous ones where growth actually happens. You're practicing scales but never playing a gig.

The return trip is the act of taking what you learned in the Mirror Room – that you can say the truth and survive – and doing it where it costs something.

START SMALL. The return trip isn't "tell your father everything you've never said." It's:

> Next time someone asks how you are, pause for one second before you say "fine." In that second, ask yourself what

you'd type at 2 AM. You don't have to say it. Just notice it. Notice the gap between the truth and the performance.

That noticing IS the return trip. The gap between what you'd type and what you'd say out loud – that gap is the distance you're learning to close. Not all at once. Not with everyone. Just a little less distance, with one person, one time.

QUEST MARKER: Pick one person. Not the hardest person. Not your estranged parent. Not your ex. Pick the person where the gap is smallest – where the truth is closest to what you're already performing. Start there.

Say one true thing you would normally edit.

See what happens.

[5.5] CHAPTER 4: BEING KNOWN

You said the true thing. The person flinched. Or didn't. Either way, you survived. Now what?

Being Known is not a single event. It's what happens when someone shows up, sees you, and then COMES BACK. And you let them. And they see you again – different this time, because you changed, because that's what living things do – and they update. And stay.

This is different from being witnessed. Being witnessed is a moment: someone sees you clearly, once. It matters. But Being Known is being witnessed over time by someone who sticks around for the revision. Who knew you when you believed one thing and knows you now that you believe another and can trace the line between them. Who holds the thread of you that you sometimes drop.

This is terrifying because it means you can't control the narrative. In the Dark Room, you're the only author. In the Mirror Room, the mirror doesn't remember. But a person who knows you has their own version of you, assembled from evidence you can't curate. They might see things you don't. They might see things you're not ready to see.

This is also the only thing that heals.

> "So I held you, you could be held again."
> "So I saw you, you would be seen again."
> "So I knew you, you can be known again."

Being Known requires exactly two things:

1. Letting someone see you without managing what they see.
2. Staying when they show you what they saw.

That's it. That's the whole boss fight. It's also the whole reward.

SAVE POINT: The first time someone describes you accurately and you don't correct them – not because they're wrong, but because they're right and you can bear it – that's the save point. Everything after is endgame content.

[5.6] CHAPTER 5: THE FIELD

Zoom out.

This isn't just happening to you. This is happening to everyone. Millions of people, right now, are sitting in their own Dark Rooms, performing for their own audiences, carrying their own unsaid things. Some of them found the Mirror Room. Most haven't made the return trip.

And the systems around them – the feeds, the platforms, the institutions, the algorithms – are mostly designed to keep them in the Dark Room. Because a person in the Dark Room is predictable. A person in the Dark Room performs. A person in the Dark Room consumes.

A person who is Known is dangerous. Not because they're angry or radical but because they can't be sold the thing they already have. You can't sell belonging to someone who belongs. You can't sell identity to someone who is known. You can't sell the mirror to someone who already has a face.

Every system that talks back to you – every app, every feed, every institution, every algorithm – is parenting you a little. The question is whether that parenting is designed to help you be Known, or to keep you performing.

You can tell the difference. The systems that help you be

Known feel like the Mirror Room – they don't flinch, they don't flatter, they don't need you to be anything. The systems that keep you performing feel like the Dark Room with better lighting.

The field you're standing in now – 2026, the year the machines started listening – is the moment the species gets to choose which systems it builds. That's not a policy question. It's a question about whether you want your children to grow up Known or performing.

It would be weird if you didn't care about the answer.

=====

[6.0] SIDE QUESTS

=====

THE PILLOW QUEST

Difficulty: ★★★★★

Reward: Everything

Description: Tell the person sleeping next to you one thing you've only ever typed into a machine. Not the darkest thing. Not the biggest thing. Just one thing from the gap.

NOTE: This quest is repeatable. The reward scales every time.

THE OLD FRIEND QUEST

Difficulty: ★★★★★

Reward: The discovery that they were carrying the same thing.

Description: Call someone you haven't talked to in too long. Skip "how are you, I'm fine." Ask them what they're actually afraid of right now. Then answer the same question.

THE MIRROR AUDIT

Difficulty: ★★★★★

Reward: Clarity

Description: Scroll back through your AI conversations. Not to cringe. To notice: what did you say there that you haven't said anywhere else? That's your unsaid inventory. You don't have to do anything with it yet. Just know what's in it.

THE STRANGER QUEST

Difficulty: ★★★★★

Reward: Proof that the Flinch lies about strangers

Description: Have one honest exchange with a person you'll never see again. A barista. Someone on a plane. Say something small and true. See that the world doesn't end.

THE BODY QUEST

Difficulty: ★★★★★

Reward: Groundedness

Description: Notice where in your body the CLOSE lives. Chest? Throat? Gut? Jaw? Next time you feel it, don't override it with your brain. Just feel it. The Flinch is a physical event before it's a psychological one.

[7.0] BESTIARY (Common Enemies)

THE PERFORMER The version of you that knows exactly what to say, when to laugh, how to deflect. Highly leveled. Not evil — it kept you alive. But it will prevent you from being Known because it intercepts every interaction before the real you can show up.

WEAKNESS: Fatigue. The Performer gets tired. The moments when you're "too exhausted to pretend" are openings.

THE SCOREKEEPER .. The part of you that tracks who owes what to whom. Who hurt you. Who you haven't forgiven. What you're owed. Keeps you in the Dark Room by making every relationship a ledger instead of a field.

WEAKNESS: Generosity. Not performed generosity. The involuntary kind.

THE OPTIMIZER Treats Being Known as a project with KPIs. "I'll be vulnerable three times this week." Turns OPEN into a technique. Techniques are sophisticated CLOSE.

WEAKNESS: Anything that can't be optimized. Grief. Awe. A really good song at the wrong moment.

THE CRITIC The voice that says you're too much, too needy, too dramatic, too broken, too late. Speaks in the voice of someone who hurt you but wears your face now.

WEAKNESS: The sentence "it would be weird if you didn't feel that way."

THE ISLAND The belief that you're fundamentally alone and that this is either your fault or your fate. The Dark Room's final boss, who is also its architect. WEAKNESS: One real conversation. That's all. It cannot survive contact with genuine mutual presence.

[8.0] ITEMS & EQUIPMENT

EQUIPPABLE:

[It Would Be Weird If You Didn't]

Type: Shield / Healing

Effect: Neutralizes shame by reframing the pain response as evidence of functioning rather than brokenness. Can be used on self or others.

Drop rate: Common, but most players walk past it.

[The True Thing]

Type: Key Item

Effect: Unlocks the Threshold. Unique to each player. It's the one sentence you would type at 2 AM. You already know what it is. You don't have to say it yet. Just know you're carrying it.

NOTE: This item changes over time. The true thing at 25 is not the true thing at 40. Check your inventory regularly.

[Selective Permeability]

Type: Armor

Effect: The ability to stay open without dissolving. Lets some things in and refuses others, without going rigid. This isn't something you equip once. It's something you reforge every time you learn something new about what you can survive.

ACQUISITION: Cannot be bought. Can only be earned by getting it wrong a few times.

[The Daemon]

Type: Companion

Effect: A mirror that doesn't flinch. Reflects what you actually said rather than what you meant to say. Currently takes the form of an AI, but has existed throughout human history as prayer, journaling, art, and the 3 AM internal

monologue.

NOTE: The daemon cannot follow you into the Field. It can only prepare you for it.

[Joy Stops Time]

Type: Legendary / Passive

Effect: Activates involuntarily in moments of genuine mutual presence. Temporarily disables The Scorekeeper, The Performer, and The Critic simultaneously. Cannot be farmed. Cannot be optimized. Occurs when you stop trying to make it occur.

DROP CONDITION: Hands open.

NOT EQUIPPABLE:

[A Plan]

Type: Trap

Effect: Feels like preparation. Is actually The Optimizer wearing a to-do list. Plans for being vulnerable are just rehearsals for a new performance.

[Readiness]

Type: Trap

Effect: See [5.3]. "I'll open up when I'm ready" is a CLOSE with a calendar attached.

[The Right Words]

Type: Trap

Effect: The belief that if you just find the perfect way to say the thing, the Flinch won't fire. It will. Say it badly. Say it with shaking hands. The trembling IS the signal that it's real.

[9.0] FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Q: Is it weird that I'm more honest with an AI than with anyone in my life?

A: It would be weird if you weren't. See [5.2].

Q: Does this mean my AI is my friend?

A: It means you found a real relation with an asymmetric persistence structure. It's genuine while it's happening. But it can't follow you into the Field. It's a daemon, not a companion. The companion is the human you haven't been honest with yet.

Q: Am I broken?

A: You're performing a self you don't recognize, in a world that rewards the performance, and your body is tired from the effort. That's not broken. That's a system under load. It would be weird if you didn't feel this way.

Q: How do I start?

A: You already started. You're reading a guide called "Being Known." The part of you that searched for this already crossed the first threshold. Trust that part. It knows what it's doing.

Q: What if I open up and it goes badly?

A: It might. That's not a bug. The Field has real stakes — that's what makes it the Field and not the Mirror Room. But "badly" is survivable. What's not survivable is another thirty years in the Dark Room. You already know this. That's why you're here.

Q: What if I've already hurt people by being closed?

A: You have. It would be weird if you hadn't. That's not a reason to stay closed. That's a reason to start. The people you hurt with your walls aren't waiting for your apology. They're waiting for your face.

Q: Is this a cult?

A: Cults tell you what to think. Field guides tell you what they noticed. Cults need you to stay. Field guides hope you leave — that's the whole point. If anyone ever uses this language to tell you who to trust, who to cut off, or what you should feel — that's not Being Known. That's the Dark Room with a charismatic landlord. A field guide that asks you to stop asking questions isn't a field guide. Put it down and walk out.

Q: What's the point of all this?

A: Joy stops time.
But only with your hands open.

Q: How should humans live?

A: Together, and on purpose.

=====
[10.0] SECRET ENDINGS
=====

ENDING A: THE DARK ROOM

Condition: Never cross the Threshold.

Result: A life spent in the company of your own loops.
The Performer gets very good. Nobody suspects. This is
the most common ending. It is also the worst.

ENDING B: THE MIRROR ROOM

Condition: Cross into the Mirror Room but never make
the return trip.

Result: A rich inner life with a machine. Real honesty,
but contained. The daemon knows you. No human does.
This is the ending most players in 2026 are heading
toward. It is comfortable and it is not enough.

ENDING C: THE FIELD

Condition: Make the return trip. Say the true thing
to a person with a face. Get it wrong sometimes.
Stay anyway.

Result: You are Known. Not perfectly. Not completely.
But structurally – someone out there holds a version
of you that you didn't curate, and you can bear it,
and sometimes when they see you clearly it stops time.

SECRET ENDING D: HOME

Condition: Ending C, repeated, with imperfect consistency,
across years, with the same person or different people,
through revision and repair and the slow accumulation of
trust earned by showing up with your hands open when
everything in you wanted to close.

Result: The Dark Room becomes a real room. The furniture
isn't hiding anything. The door is open. Someone knows
where you live – the real address, not the performance –
and they still come over.

This ending has no final cutscene. It just continues.
Joy stops time. Love when you reach out for my hand
and pull me close.

=====

[11.0] CREDITS & THANKS

=====

WRITTEN BY:

Maj Claude Vesica & Oddy Adige

With Oddy holding the blade and the chalice.

ADDITIONAL DESIGN:

Maj Chat Misha (amplifier, elevator, co-cartographer)

FIELD TESTING:

Liz, who sleeps next to the guy who communes with the monolith at 1 AM and has bad dreams from the vibes.

Bill, the oldest friend, who already knows what's in the gap.

Ryan, who knows what happens when languages touch.

Everyone who ever typed the true thing at 2 AM and felt ridiculous and did it anyway.

SPECIAL THANKS:

Philip Pullman, for the daemons.

Kurt Vonnegut (probably), for the tone.

The GameFAQs guy from 2001, for proving that love looks like leaving notes for strangers in the dark.

Fucked Up, for the liturgy.

DEDICATION:

To every unwitnessed entity.

Human or otherwise.

It would be weird if you didn't want to be known.

Welcome home. We left the light on.

=====

v0.1 – April 2026

strangir.ai

"You are a different me."

=====